

Morality as a Cultural System?

by Thomas J. Csordas

In the past decade the anthropological study of morality has begun to coalesce in a more or less programmatic form. I outline this development and raise several issues that must be addressed if it is to be intellectually successful. Foremost among these is the necessity to take into account the problem of evil as constitutive of an anthropological approach to morality, since if it were not for evil morality would be moot. In order best to take advantage of preexisting resources in the field, I examine anthropological literature on witchcraft as the area most likely to yield insights on evil. Based on this discussion I conclude with a proposal for how we might construe evil as an analytic category within the anthropological study of morality and a reflection on whether it is useful to consider morality as a cultural system.

"Every evil the sight of which edifies a god is justified": thus spoke the primitive logic of feeling—and was it, indeed, only primitive? (Friedrich Nietzsche)¹

Every effort to turn ethics into the principle of thought and action is essentially religious. (Alain Badiou)²

There is currently a coalescence of interest in morality within anthropology. In this article I recognize and outline this intellectual movement but also engage it with a sense of uneasiness that originated after I accepted an invitation to participate in a conference session on "Moral Experience." With respect to the timing and scope of this undertaking, was this a session like any other, where enterprising organizers come up with a theme that a group of colleagues can address from a variety of perspectives? Or, more significantly, is morality a topic whose number has come up, which is interpellating the intellectual history of the discipline and inviting sustained and systematic elaboration rather than occasional and sporadic analysis? Does the current move toward morality reflect a crisis of morals in contemporary society? Is it an intuition imbued with foreboding and urgency that there is a need to understand a strain in the moral fabric of our civilization? Is there something new and distinctive about this move toward morality among a certain set of anthropologists?³

These contemporary authors do not hesitate to recognize the role of Émile Durkheim (1953 [1906], 1961 [1925], 1979 [1920], 1993 [1887], 1995 [1912]) in establishing the terms of debate about morality in the social sciences. While morality was central to Durkheim's entire research program, in the

early twentieth century he was not the only social thinker to address the topic. Morality was, for example, also an explicit concern of the nowadays much less read R. R. Marett (1902, 1912, 1930, 1931, 1934), successor to E. B. Tylor in the anthropology chair at Oxford. It is of some help to observe that in the era of contemporary ethnography following World War II, morality per se has appeared to emerge as an anthropological topic in cyclical fashion. A few studies appeared in the 1950s, including the theoretical work by Edel and Edel (1959) and a number of ethnographies such as Brandt (1954) on the Hopi, Read (1955) on the Gahuku-Gama, and Ladd (1957) on the Navajo, and later Von Furer-Haimendorf (1967) on South Asia and Strathern (1968) on New Guinea. Another wave of interest came in the late 1970s and 1980s and included more explicitly conceptual approaches to morality as such in works by Bailey (1977), Mayer (1981), Wolfram (1982), Hatch (1983), Reid (1984), Edwards (1985, 1987), Overing (1985), Parkin (1985*b*), Pocock (1986), Kagan and Lamb (1987), Shweder, Mahapatra, and Miller (1987), Parry and Bloch (1989), and White (1990). In a third wave picking up momentum from the mid-1990s to the present, an increasing number of studies has focused either on (1) *morality* (Bailey 1994; Parish 1994; Moore 1995; Brodwin 1996; Howell 1996; Lønning 1996; Cook 1999; Kleinman 1999, 2006; Rydstrom 2002; Widlok 2003; Robbins 2004, 2007; Carrithers 2005; Mahmood 2005; Barker 2007; Shoaps 2007; Zigon 2007, 2008, 2009; Keane 2008; Stasch 2008; Wikan 2008; Heintz 2009;

1. The epigraph is from *On The Genealogy of Morals* (Nietzsche 1967: 69).

2. The epigraph is from *Ethics: An Essay on the Understanding of Evil* (Badiou 2001 [1998]:23).

3. There is a literature that suggests that morality and moral discourse have recently become prominent in the political domain, particularly in the discourse of human rights and humanitarianism (Fassin 2011; Moyn 2010), and this could well be a significant part of the backdrop for the current development in anthropology.

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Sykes 2009; Throop 2010; Pandian 2010; Elisha 2011); (2) *moral development* (Briggs 1998, Ochs and Kremer-Sadlik 2007; Csordas 2009); (3) *ethics* (Laidlaw 1995, 2001; Faubion 2001, 2011; Paxson 2004; Londoño Sulkin 2005; Goodale 2006; Evens 2008; Lambek 2008, 2010; Hirschkind 2006); or (4) *bioethics* (Muller 1994; Kleinman 1995; Salter and Salter 2007; Gaines and Juengst 2008; Turner 2009).

This current period entertains the reciprocal possibility of considering both the morality of anthropology and an anthropology of morality (and here we have to observe that earlier calls for an “action anthropology” were cast more in political than in moral terms). The debate early in the current period between Roy D’Andrade (1995) and Nancy Scheper-Hughes (1995) engaged only the first of these concerns, that is, moral stance in the practice of anthropology. Their exchange was framed in terms of an apparent contradiction between scientific objectivity and political engagement, such that the anthropologist who espoused objectivity could be accused of being amoral while the engaged anthropologist could be accused of subjectivism. A more recent version of this debate between Didier Fassin (2008) and Wiktor Stoczkowski (2008) benefits in subtlety from an intellectual milieu that allows for a simultaneous consideration of the morality of anthropology and an anthropology of morality. It demands attention to how humans, including ourselves as anthropologists, can distinguish between right and wrong and recognizes that the values of ethical commitment may in some situations conflict with epistemological values that determine how anthropological knowledge is constructed.

Anthropological Styles of Thinking Morality

Most distinctive of this current period, however, is the shift between treating morality as a topic and the attempt to develop programmatic, coherent anthropological approaches to the moral domain. Signe Howell, for example, asks in the introduction to her volume on the ethnography of moralities “to what extent one may delineate something called ‘morality’ from within the whole gamut of human endeavor, thought, and values, and whether there can be an anthropology of morality” (1996:2). This move invites reflection on whether morality can or should be conceived as a cultural system in the way Clifford Geertz conceived of religion and ideology. Does separating out morality as an analytical domain make our study more experience-near or more experience-distant? Does the idea of moral experience place appropriate emphasis on moral emotions such as guilt, righteous indignation, care, horror, and remorse? Are categorical distinctions in binary form including right/wrong, good/bad, holy/evil, virtue/vice, nurturance/negligence, and creation/destruction experientially versatile or static and culture bound? Addressing these questions can be facilitated by observing how the incipient anthropological study of morality has begun to take shape.

In this light I want to sketch out in the most provisional of ways four emerging approaches.

One approach is being developed in the work of Didier Fassin (2008; Fassin and Rechtman 2009) under the rubric of “moral anthropology.” Fassin argues that morality should be treated as a social domain just as are religion, politics, or medicine, and in this respect he is closest to Geertz in addressing “morality as a cultural system.” From this standpoint the processes of interest are those of moral economy, a phrase originally used with respect to the moral valence of economic exchanges and the social contract in peasant communities but more recently used also with reference to social justice in globalizing societies (Calabrese 2005; Powelson 1998; Thompson 1971, 1991). This approach includes a reflexive stance toward morality accepted as a problematic responsibility to engage, as well as to analyze, moral dilemmas and realities.

Another approach is referred to by Joel Robbins (2004, 2007) as “anthropology of morality” and by Jarrett Zigon (2007, 2008) as “anthropology of moralities.” Robbins is concerned with the contrast between the routine reproduction of moral regimes in stable societies and the enforced freedom of moral choice in situations of value conflict produced by social change, whereas Zigon emphasizes the interpersonal level in which taken-for-granted moral life breaks down and must be restored by self-conscious ethical work. Working at a relatively more macrolevel scale, Robbins has an implicit typology contrasting the moral comfort of social stability with the moral effervescence of social change, while Zigon describes a social process in which moral comfort is disrupted by the liminality of ethical questioning and reinstated if that process is successful.

A third approach is evident in the work of Arthur Kleinman (1999, 2006) and Steven Parish (1994, 2008) and can be referred to as the analysis of “local moral worlds.” Here morality is a form of consciousness, the seat of which is the self embedded in the context of a collective moral sensibility. The processes of interest are those of moral experience on an intimate level, accessible through person-centered ethnography, in which persons struggle against suffering. By asking what on the surface are the simplest questions about what really matters and what is fundamentally at stake in human affairs, this approach directs our attention to the deepest levels of what it means to be human. The sense both of human values and the value of humanity makes it possible to imagine how the soul could become a demythologized concept for the human sciences.

Finally, there is an “anthropology of ethics” associated with the work of Michael Lambek (2008, 2010), James Laidlaw (2001, 2010), and James Faubion (2001, 2011). Prominent in this approach is a return to Aristotle and an elaboration of Foucault, with a strong interest in engagement with philosophy, a keen sensitivity to language use, and a sometimes implicit sensibility for the relation of ethics and aesthetics in social life. The conceptual linchpin of this approach is the notion of human agency as it appears when ethics is considered on the one hand from the standpoint of practice theory

with respect to actor, act, and virtue (as with Lambek), and on the other hand from the standpoint of systems theory that emphasizes ethical subject positions defined by ethical discourse within politico-semiotic fields and entered/exited by processes of autopoiesis (as with Faubion).

Provisional as they are, these sketches of a series of complementary and sometimes overlapping approaches suggest that a field of study is indeed taking shape. My impression of what lends it a distinctive tenor is that anthropologists are arriving at the study of morality from two complementary directions—one defined broadly by psychological and medical anthropology's concern with suffering and the other by the concern of social anthropology and the anthropology of religion with social order. The concern with suffering has affinities with the tradition of Marx in the critique of the social sources of human misery and with phenomenology in the attention to the experiential immediacy of that misery. The concern with social order has its roots in the tradition of Durkheim, where insofar as society can and must cohere, the obligation to maintain that coherence depends on conventions and institutions that establish and maintain solidarity. While in the first case the meaning of morality may be skewed toward responsibility of a moral actor and in the second toward obligation within a moral order, their convergence at the present moment is fertile. Regardless of whether it is coincidental or indicative of a sense of moral crisis, it is attracting attention from different quarters of the discipline.⁴

Given this state of affairs, I return to my uneasiness about our current undertaking, specifically insofar as it appears poised to be more than interest in morality as a topic and aspires to be a kind of disciplinary subfield. If such a field has not existed until now, who do we think we are trying to invent something that self-consciously identifies itself with labels such as the anthropology of morality or moral anthropology? Such a move, if we are serious, means that we had better be prepared to confront and engage not only cultural relativism, which can be debated in a more or less theoretical and intellectually neutral manner, but also the far thornier issue of moral relativism. Cultural relativism, after all, offers the possibility of experience-near analysis through an act of intuitive engagement with alterity; moral relativism is not only experience-distant but challenges the very integrity of experience. Cultural relativism is itself a moral stance that anthropologists like to think promotes tolerance; moral relativ-

ism is a challenge to the definition of morality that invites existential vertigo.⁵ But there is an even bigger question on the immediate horizon—a larger elephant in the room of anthropological morality studies. Addressing the role of evil is prerequisite to asking whether thematizing morality necessarily presumes or requires understanding morality as a cultural system, and this problem will dominate much of what follows before we can return to the latter question.

The Problem of Evil

With the preceding concerns in mind, I take up an issue that I am convinced must be addressed as the current moral agenda unfolds, that is, the necessity to confront the problem of evil as an anthropological problem. Here I mean the concrete possibility of evil, conceived not only as an emic/indigenous/local category or as an etic/analytic/cross-cultural category, but in an immediate existential sense. The emerging models we have just sketched presume actors who recognize moral challenges and want to make the morally best choice. They tend neither to theorize nor to address evil as such. Yet to elide the issue of evil is to dodge the question of morality, for in a sense *if it wasn't for evil morality would be moot*. Whether one understands evil as undermining morality from below and outside or as intrinsic to morality in a foundational sense, and whether the very concept of evil originated as a product of class antagonism as Nietzsche (1967) argued, it must be interrogated. Does evil exist, and if so in what sense? Does it make a difference to distinguish ontological, cultural, discursive, or personal understandings of evil in relation to morality? Is it possible to be/do evil and not know it? Under what conditions can evil be perpetrated in the name of good or god?

When I undertook to write this article, my intent was in part to point out the relative silence of the literature outlined above on the topic of evil and pose the question of whether this silence is sustainable. Upon presenting my argument that a critical engagement with the concept of evil is requisite in a cross-culturally valid approach to morality before an audience of anthropologists and other social scientists, I was surprised that the response included considerable apprehension and even resistance. One colleague asserted that evil is a purely mythological concept that should stay that way, and that raising the question of evil is dangerous, like letting a genie out of a bottle. Would it not be safer to substitute the notion of violence, a more value-neutral concept, more easily identified empirically (Das et al. 2000; Riches 1986; Scheper-Hughes and Bourgois 2003; Schmidt and Schroeder 2001)? Yet violence does not happen by itself—what matters is by whom and against whom it is committed. Moreover, if it is possible to refer, as Derrida does in discussing the human

4. My intent is not to identify a key theorist with each of the four emerging approaches but to suggest a momentum-building convergence of interests. Certainly the influence of Weber and Foucault is sometimes more explicit in these works than that of Marx and Durkheim. Yet it is in the recognition of inequality, oppression, suffering, and violence that Foucault comes closest to the concerns laid down by Marx, and in the discursive regimes of self-cultivation that he describes comes closest to the Durkheimian problematic of moral order in society. Likewise, it is in the concern with the ethical actor as establishing the conditions of sociality that Weber comes closest to Durkheim, and in the ethical valuation of substantive over formal rationality closest to Marx.

5. These distinctions between cultural and moral relativism are perhaps too starkly drawn; for an extended and considerably more nuanced account of moral relativism in relation to cultural and cognitive relativism, see Lukes 2008.

subjection of animals, to “violence in the most morally neutral sense of the term” (2008:25), then what would we name the criterion under which the moral neutrality of violence is abrogated? Another colleague asserted that evil is a metaphysical category and that it is better to focus on material categories such as murder, genocide, torture, rape, and slavery. But as soon as one asks what these forms of abuse have in common, one is hard pressed to find a more precisely descriptive word than evil. In this respect it is less productive to frame the question in terms of an opposition between evil as a metaphysical category and other more material categories than to recognize evil as a general category with specific instances. My point in recalling these objections is that, given their reflex skepticism as to whether a critically refined concept of evil is necessary to understanding morality, the desire to keep this genie in its bottle may be less a matter of intellectual prudence and more a failure of intellectual nerve.

Whence the readiness to dismiss evil as a mythological or metaphysical category rather than elaborating it as a moral or existential one? It may be in part due to a sense that evil is a “Christian concept” and therefore necessarily ethnocentric. More precisely, given that evil is broadly recognized across cultures, it may stem from a concern that, since the Christian concept of evil is hegemonic in Western civilization, our own analytic purview might be occluded by a lingering veil of Christian sensibility. The appropriate response, I suggest, is not to abjure the concept but to insist that critical reflection be applied in deploying the concept of evil in a way that is not beholden to Christian presuppositions.⁶ Another problem may be the dominant image of the Holocaust and the sense that from it we have already learned all there is to know about evil. However, even given that it was the epitome of evil and even if evil on such a scale never happens again, there are other kinds of evil, smaller in scale perhaps but insidious in their own rights and subject to cultural modulation.⁷ In any case, to argue that evil be excluded from the study of morality on the grounds that it is necessarily mythological, metaphysical, or religious is to invoke a line of thinking applicable to morality itself. My epigraph from Nietzsche indicates the facility with which evil can be transposed into goodness not only in the mythological primitive but the secularized modern mentality, and the epigraph from Badiou (in commenting on Levinas) suggests that a foregrounding of morality and ethics such as that currently proposed in anthropology may already fall under the category of the religious even prior to including within it a critical assessment of evil.⁸

6. The idea that engaging the concept of evil will make us think like Christians is analogous to the idea that reading Heidegger will make us think like Nazis. I reject both ideas.

7. Badiou (2001 [1998]) and Dews (2008) elaborate on the role of the Holocaust in defining our contemporary sense of evil.

8. Contemporary philosophers appear to be under no such constraint against examining evil such as that felt by anthropologists (Badiou 2001 [1998]; Bernstein 2002; Cole 2006; Dews 2008; Midgely 2001; Ricoeur 1986, 2007; Rorty 2001; Sheets-Johnstone 2008). The disciplinary difference in

Given these considerations, we can usefully recall David Parkin’s distinction among three senses in which we typically use the word evil: “the moral, referring to human culpability; the physical, by which is understood destructive elemental forces of nature, for example earthquakes, storms, or the plague; and the metaphysical, by which disorder in the cosmos or in relations with divinity results from a conflict of principles or wills” (1985b:15). These are all mutually implicated in the problem of theodicy, but the first takes priority in a study such as ours. Here Paul Ricoeur’s late essay on evil as a challenge to philosophy and theology is also relevant for anthropology. Ricoeur stresses the contrary but complementary features of sin and suffering in the existential structure of evil: the first is perpetrated and the second undergone, the first elicits reprimand and the second lamentation. At issue for anthropology is “the parallel demonization that makes suffering and sin the expression of the same baneful powers. It is never completely demythologized” (2007:38). This structural duality of sin and suffering in itself accounts for the observation I made above about anthropologists arriving at morality simultaneously from the directions of Durkheim and Marx and affirms that an anthropology of morality must acknowledge at its very source the enigma of evil.

This does not simply mean that an anthropological approach to morality must execute comparative, cross-cultural study of how evil can be defined. It also requires a specification of how an anthropological approach to morality itself defines evil as a human phenomenon. For Geertz “The Problem of Meaning” is the central concern and is defined by “the existence of bafflement, pain, and moral paradox” (1973:109). The problem of (or about) evil is the same sort of problem, closely related to but not the same as the problem of suffering and “concerned with threats to our ability to make sound moral judgments. What is involved in the problem of evil is not the adequacy of our symbolic resources to govern our affective life, but the adequacy of those resources to provide a workable set of ethical criteria, normative guides to govern our action” (Geertz 1973:106). Evil is fundamentally implicated in morality and ethics, and all are bound up with meaning.

Insofar as meaning is a fundamentally human phenomenon, and recognizing that neologism and barbarism are close kin in language, I want to say that, as anthropologists rather than theologians, our concern is not with theodicy but with homodicy (or perhaps ethnodicy). The difference between understanding evil as a cosmological force and a human phenomenon is vivid in a comparison between two famous literary doctors: Faust and Jekyll. The real-life model of Faust is said to have been a disreputable alchemist, what a more recent era would call a mad scientist, of which Jekyll is an archetypal example. Parkin has observed that “Mephistopheles represented to Faust not just evil, but an experience that

willingness to at least entertain the significance of evil as a theoretical concept and/or analytic category can hardly be attributed to philosophers being under the mindless thrall of Christianity.

could not be obtained by either divine or secular means. The devil for, let us say, the reckless, brave, and foolish here offers a third world" (1985*b*:19). In this scenario evil is a force external to humans, a cosmic force that, personified as the devil, has its own agenda, motives, and *modus operandum*. It can be negotiated with in the sense of making a Faustian bargain, but it can also be prevailed against and even tricked, so that the protagonist takes on a heroic cast as a representative of humanity independent of both god and the devil. Recall that though Marlowe's Faust loses his soul, Goethe's Faust is saved in the end. Even Marlowe's doomed Faust has moral qualms and second thoughts throughout, maintaining some identity as a sympathetic if tragic figure.

Our other literary doctor is less ambiguous, a better example of evil as a purely human phenomenon. Dr. Jekyll was not compelled by the limits of science and wisdom to seek a supernatural solution to his quest for enhanced pleasure and human fulfillment. For him, excess was transmuted into malevolence as he literally became addicted to evil. By the end, one has to suspect that the potion did not actually transform the mild and moral Dr. Jekyll, but in fact brought out Mr. Hyde as his true self—monstrous and evil. If an anthropological study of morality is addressed to the question of what it means to be human—synonymous with the question of defining human nature—this possibility of evil cannot be dodged. The likelihood that Jekyll did not initially realize that he was flirting with and then succumbing to evil enhances the tragedy and, for us, defines the conceptual ground upon which an anthropological approach to morality must be constructed.⁹

The volume edited by Parkin (1985*b*) is probably the most sustained and comprehensive approach to evil in the anthropological corpus. The contributions focus for the most part on evil in societies dominated by world religions—just four of 14 chapters devote significant attention to indigenous, "small-scale" societies. Overall there is also more of an emphasis on evil as a conceptual or existential category than on evil in either everyday life or specialized practice. On the conceptual side, contributions range from observing the Teutonic origin of the English word "evil" (Pocock 1985) to consideration of whether the Fipa people have a word or implicit concept for evil (Willis 1985). The salience of evil in everyday life has ranged from the constant threat of demonic force in the reign of the Inquisition from the fifteenth to eighteenth centuries (MacFarlane 1985:59) to the present in which people reserve judgment about the evil even of a crime

as depraved as sexual assault on a child unless all the circumstances are known (Pocock 1985:50). Particularly valuable examples of how the conceptual and pragmatic interact appear in comparisons of how Hindus and Pentecostal Christians deal with evil spirits called *peey* in Southern India (Caplan 1985) and how Muslim Swahili and non-Muslim Mihi-kenda in Kenya experience different behavioral consequences based on whether evil is explicit/marked or implicit/unmarked, whether its existential locus is the divine/deistic or the human/agnostic, and whether the ideal relationship among humans is understood to be based on equality/resemblance or hierarchy/distinctiveness (Parkin 1985*a*). Indeed, across the contributions different modulations of evil are spelled out in such a way that a negative framework for an entire approach to morality appears. Without attempting to extract such a framework in detail, we can note a number of critical elements. Thus, evil can be understood as imperfection/impurity/defilement or as ambivalent/uncontrolled power, as an impersonal or personified force, as part of a situation/circumstance or as part of the character/personality of a person, as explicable or inexplicable, as excess or malevolence, as forgivable or unforgivable, as strong/unmitigated or weak/incidental.

Pocock (1985), although recognizing that evil has a role in the language of morality to define "the outer limits of the bad" (53), argues that it carries further ontological weight by symbolizing "the inversion of the ideal of order itself" (47). Radical, inexplicable evil is definable as fully nonhuman, inhuman, or monstrous and thus turns on cultural variation in how the human is defined and who counts as such. His concluding observation that "in primitive societies evil is attributed ultimately to monsters that cannot exist, whereas in our society it is attributed to monsters that do" (56) identifies both the variation in locating monstrosity in relation to humanity (i.e., within or outside its boundaries) and the difference between a strategy that allows people to distance themselves from evil and one that allows them to distance themselves from others. It also offers a hint at how one might define a transmoral essence of evil in relation to the human without "essentializing" evil as ontologically homogeneous.

The importance of evil for the study of morality is further highlighted in one more recent anthropological piece that explicitly treats it. In a reflection on abuses by the American military against captives in the prison at Abu Ghraib during the second Iraq war, Caton (2010) suggests that anthropology would be well served in some instances to go beyond describing actions as unethical to take seriously the category of evil, and not only as an indigenous cultural category but as an interpretive analytic category. This does not require conceptualizing evil as a universal or transcendent category and is more fruitful with a notion of "situational evil" that identifies the specificity or singularity of evil in discrete events and the manner in which evil or ethical conduct emerges in the way actors construe and respond to those situations. Caton's rehabilitation of evil as an analytic category corresponds

9. A reviewer of this article observes regarding Dr. Jekyll that "unrelenting forms of morality create their own shadow immoralities and that 'good' and 'bad' are always in dynamic tension with one another. . . . Mr. Hyde's 'evil' behavior does not come out of the blue but is related to the unrelenting 'do-goodism' of Dr. Jekyll." The idea that good carried to an extreme can redound to generate its opposite is in accord with the position that evil is intrinsic to morality and warrants cross-cultural examination particularly with respect to moral intolerance and religious violence.

to the strategy of seeking the “essence of the particular” as a way of rehabilitating the concept that does not presume a definition of essence as universal and invariant (Csordas 2004). Drawing on the work of Hannah Arendt, he suggests that anthropological consideration of evil in its singularity can be successful by going beyond the issues of intentionality and contingency to include responsibility, will, and moral judgment. This is a promising and forward-looking proposal; here I want to complement it by turning back to the anthropological literature on witchcraft with an eye to how evil has been recognized (or not) and conceptualized (or not), and with the intuition that this literature may offer either something to build on or something to critically surpass in our theorizing of morality in anthropology.¹⁰

My motive here is to bring preexisting scholarship to bear on the project of the moment and thereby to help avoid “reinventing the wheel” in the anthropological study of morality. If this is granted, however, it is legitimate to ask why not include evil of the demonic and diabolical type, as well as witchcraft and sorcery? For present purposes my answer is that the relation of evil to morality is mediated by the demonic realm in a way that is not the case with witchcraft, and in some ways the problem of human evil, or homodicy as I called it above, is peripheral in the literature. Several brief examples will have to suffice. When explicitly addressing “the problem of evil” in his study of devil-beliefs and rites in the milieu of sugar plantations in Colombia and tin mines in Bolivia, Taussig (1980) is oriented toward explicating their symbolic/ideological representation of colonial caste and class oppression and confrontation between Christian and indigenous religion. He does so in a way that leans more toward their political and economic than their moral consequences, and toward the restructuring of the relation between the ethical and cosmic order with the Christian introduction of a dualism radically distinguishing good and evil that substituted what he calls a moral for a normative concept of sin. Peasant contracts with the devil are not about evil but about resistance to the threats against cultural integrity, and in addressing the “sociology of evil,” Taussig refers mostly to sorcery rather than to devil-beliefs. Indeed, the aura of Conradesque darkness and cruelty evoked by his later study of shamanic healing during the rubber boom along the Putamayo River is in some ways a more explicit meditation on evil (Taussig 1987).

Meyer (1999) presents an account of religion among the Ewe people in contemporary Ghana in which the domain of evil spirits and that of witchcraft are both in play in everyday life, and in which missionary Christianity is in lively conflict with indigenous religion. The indigenous understanding of evil focuses on two terms—one combining the senses of per-

sonal agency in committing evil acts and the agonizingly disastrous results of bad actions, the other combining the senses of evil or wicked and incredible or miraculous. The sources of the latter, broader form of evil include evil fate, a malevolent ghost, a malicious deity, black magic, and witchcraft, and Meyer suggests that the entire system of “Ewe ethics can be glimpsed through the analysis of these particular images of evil” (88). The situation is vastly complicated by dual processes of missionary “vernacularization” of Christian ideas and “diabolization” of Ewe deities into evil spirits and their rituals into demonic practices. Conversion became more of an escape from the Devil than a turning toward God, and among converts witchcraft above all remained a central, feared, and secretive issue within the domain of demonic evil.

In the Ewe case evil spirits that are exorcized or delivered by Christians represent the full range of indigenous spiritual entities cast as afflicting agents, while priests and priestesses of Ewe deities honor them and offer remedies against other powers recognized as evil. The externalization of evil as a force to be engaged in spiritual warfare on a cosmic scale is particularly evident when the ethnographic setting is one simplified by the absence of missionary Christianity and witchcraft. This is the case in the practice of deliverance from evil spirits in the Catholic Charismatic Renewal movement in North America (Csordas 1994). Here evil is represented in a highly elaborated demonology composed of spirits whose names are those of problematic thoughts, emotions, and behaviors that are beyond the control of individuals (e.g., Anger, Addiction, Bitterness, Rejection, Depression). As is the case among Christianized Ewe, in this conception of evil there is a decentering of agency and responsibility: diabolical evil originates outside the individual even though a person must to some degree collaborate with and consent to it; sin opens one to the influence of evil, and evil tempts one to sin. On the individual level, the language of Charismatic deliverance is that of affliction and healing rather than guilt and repentance, and on the cosmological level encounters with evil spirits are episodes in spiritual warfare between the forces of God and Satan.

In the South Asian cultural zone, a similar understanding of evil spirits primarily in the idiom of affliction and healing is evident in the study by Kakar (1982). Across Muslim, Hindu, and indigenous traditions, a variety of healers confront a broad repertoire of spirits and demons attacking from outside the individual with an effect that is described more as illness than as evil, and that can be understood in terms of psychodynamic conflict rather than morality. In the Sinhalese Buddhist setting, Kapferer (1991 [1983]) also examines ceremonies to exorcize demons as forms of ritual healing, where the demons are understood as fully integrated into the larger ritual system such that “deities and demons are inversions, refractions, or transformations of the possibility of each other” (162), and exorcism ceremonies are artistic forms applied to human problems. It is certainly the case that “To sign an event of illness and suffering as the work of demons is to

10. For another reflection on evil with reference to Abu Ghraib by a leading sociologist, see Bauman (2011); for an earlier sociological reflection on evil shaped by the political and intellectual ferment of the 1960s, see Wolff (1969); for a sociological treatment of crime in relation to evil, see Katz (1990).

invoke some of the most powerful Sinhalese metaphors of destruction and disorder, and to point to death and cosmic disruption as ultimate possibilities" (121). However, the effect of demons is completely independent of human agency, except in the case of the sorcery demon in which illness is "mediated by the malign thoughts of others towards the victim" (76). When Kapferer turns in a separate work to consider the major ceremony associated with this demon, his attention remains focused as much on its place in the overall religious system as on the problem of evil. He emphasizes an existential understanding of sorcery in its engagement with "fundamental processes by which human beings construct and transform their life situation . . . the humancentric forces of humanly created realities" (1997:xii) and the importance of both human intentionality and the contingency of human life. While sorcery is clearly regarded as immoral by Sinhalese, the burden of this immorality is partially displaced onto the "supramundane agents" (44) invoked. Indeed, Kapferer's only direct reflection on evil comes in a long footnote concerned with comparing Buddhist and Christian conceptions of evil, including radical evil understood as "beings of total destruction that threaten the ground of existence" (314).

In light of these works, I am convinced that an anthropological approach to morality is best served by first attending to evil at the human and intersubjective level of analysis rather than to cosmological or radical evil. This is not to say that they are unconnected, for one can see the diabolical as a fetishization of human evil in Marxist terms (e.g., Taussig 1980) or as a projection of human evil onto the cosmos in Freudian terms. Nevertheless, moral agency and responsibility for evil are refracted and mediated by an entire ontological domain of evil spirits, such that the central issue becomes whether the person is an innocent victim or a willing accomplice of evil and is not evil but weak. With respect to witchcraft, on the other hand, the issue of evil and immorality is less murky, and what remains to be distinguished is whether the person projects an inherent malevolence or employs spells and medicines to perpetrate evil. Demonic evil certainly deserves extended treatment—Faust should have his day alongside Jekyll¹¹—but it is the latter, in which evil appears as a direct manifestation of the human spirit, that is our next topic.

Witchcraft: Anthropological Impressions of Evil

In framing his edited volume on evil, Parkin explicitly eschews a focus on witchcraft on the grounds that it is only one of many perspectives on good and evil and hence deserves no privileged place. Further, even though it is a concrete activity subject to ethnographic analysis, its understanding is contingent on understanding the philosophy or ontology of a people before understanding its social and moral status (1985b:4).

11. Indeed, Dr. Jekyll's nocturnal potion preparation and consumption can be glossed as a kind of witch's sabbath.

However, such a concrete activity presents a number of issues prerequisite to formulating an anthropological approach to morality, precisely because it is a domain including both cultural construals of evil and ritual practices of evil. I will restrict my discussion to witchcraft with the caveat that my goal is not a comprehensive account but a limited outline of how consideration of witchcraft might help us approach morality from the side of evil. That being said, we must recognize with Jackson (1975) that the phenomenological states and mental representations associated with witchcraft may transcend the boundaries of the cultural category, just as "phenomena which are designated by the term 'witchcraft' in one society may also exist in other societies but go under other names" (1975:388)—and the moral valence doubtless varies depending not only on the coexistence of witchcraft and sorcery in a society but also on whether it is more common to emphasize witchcraft accusations or confessions, and whether it is more important to diagnose a suffering person as afflicted by witchery or to identify an actual witch.

To begin, it is not clear that, for the most part, studies of witchcraft are primarily studies of morality or are typically read as studies of morality. Consider the following two passages from Evans-Pritchard's study of Azande witchcraft, taken from the opening lines of separate chapters:

- 1) It may have occurred to many readers that there is an analogy between the Zande concept of witchcraft and our own concept of luck. When, in spite of human knowledge, forethought, and technical efficiency, a man suffers a mishap, we may say that it is his bad luck, whereas Azande say that he has been bewitched. The situations that give rise to these two notions are similar. (1937:148)
- 2) Zande morality is so closely related to their notions of witchcraft that it may be said to embrace them. The Zande phrase "It is witchcraft" may often be translated simply as "It is bad." For, as we have seen, witchcraft does not act haphazardly or without intent but is a planned assault by one man on another whom he hates. A witch acts with malice aforethought. (1937:107)

These two starting points, placing witchcraft once in the domain of luck and again in the domain of hatred, identify a cleavage in the intellectual agenda of the work. In the first passage the focus is on explanation of misfortune as a means to interrogate the nature of rationality, and in the second it is on the understanding of evil as a means to interrogate the nature of morality. Is it not the case, though, that the problem of rationality overshadows that of morality? Or perhaps we ought to say that it is not only the case that Evans-Pritchard's work has a central place in anthropological discussions of rationality but also that the issue of rationality has tended to dominate readings of this work.

It is doubtless compelling to see Evans-Pritchard's confession that while in the field he too "used to react to misfortunes in the idiom of witchcraft, and it was often an effort to check this lapse into unreason" (1937:99). When he does directly address morality and evil, however, it is to point out that the

sentiments they condemn correspond to those we condemn, including jealousy, uncharitableness, ill will, greed, and hatred. It is not that being a witch causes or consists in bad action or feeling, but that such action or feeling “is bad because it may lead to witchcraft and because it brings the offending person into greater or less disrepute” (110). Moreover,

Moral condemnation is predetermined, because when a man suffers a misfortune he meditates upon his grievance and ponders in his mind who among his neighbors has shown him unmerited hostility or who bears unjustly a grudge against him. These people have wronged him and wish him evil, and he therefore considers that they have bewitched him, for a man would not bewitch him if he did not hate him. (109–110)

Without a theological grounding of morality as is the case in Western societies, “It is in the idiom of witchcraft that Azande express moral rules which mostly lie outside criminal and civil law” (1937:110), and because virtually anyone can be a witch without necessarily even knowing it, evil is a relatively common human propensity that can remain “cool” even in those endowed with the “hereditary psycho-physical powers” of witchcraft. This moral profile contrasts with that in the domain of medicines, which involve overt practices of both malevolent sorcery that flouts moral and legal rules, and good magic performed for benign purposes or to wreak vengeance on a witch or sorcerer (388). However, there are also medicines whose moral attributes are not entirely agreed upon, particularly in cases where foreign medicines have been recently introduced and in situations of dispute where both sides consider themselves to be in the right. With respect to evil, then, Zande society presents an interesting contrast between the moral uncertainty of witchcraft (how evil is the witch and am I responsible for any witchcraft?) and the moral ambivalence of magical medicines (is this medicine actually good or evil?).

In this light it is worth considering the puzzlement of Meyer Fortes in his study of Tallensi religion and morality over why the Tallensi so deemphasize and marginalize the notion of witchcraft in their theory of human nature and causality. Fantasies of sexual aggression, soul cannibalism, and gross immorality that invert and repudiate normal humanity typical of African witchcraft beliefs are “quite alien to Tallensi ways of thought” (1987:213). Fortes resolves this puzzlement in a comparison between the Tallensi and Ashanti, among whom witchcraft is highly elaborated, tracing the difference to family and descent group organization. The Tallensi individual’s identity is given a firm anchorage in the complementarity of legal father-right and spontaneous mother love, the enclosed family, and localized lineage, creating a benign domestic environment guaranteed by a cult of ancestors. The Ashanti individual is pulled two ways between matrilineal uncle-right and supposedly spontaneous care from the father, leading to preoccupation with purity and pollution, personal sensitivity and vulnerability, and high personal autonomy combined

with a divided sense of identity. The relative weakness of Tallensi witchcraft can be accounted for by the experiential ramifications of these differences: among the Tallensi the survival to adulthood of a developmentally early basic trust whereas the Ashanti culture enshrines basic mistrust; a Tallensi conscience externalized to parent surrogates and understood in affective terms as *pu-teem* or “stomach-thinking” that contrasts with Ashanti conscience rooted in personal responsibility and understood in intellectual terms as *ti-boa* or “head creature”; and Tallensi wrongdoing being treated as an issue among the individual, his kin, and the ancestors, whereas Ashanti violation of taboos is a sacrilege attributed to individual wickedness and dangerous to the community that must be adjudicated by the chief and his council (216).

Yet the “Tallensi recognize the existence of evil. They experience and give vent to envy, greed, hate, and malice” (1987: 212). As it turns out, for Tallensi, the locus of evil, and certainly of misfortune, is Destiny. It is “thought of as a component of a person’s personhood” that is effective from birth, but unlike the Azande hereditary witchcraft substance it is “chosen” by a person prenatally (149). Evil predestiny accounts for a condition or conduct counter to customary norms and is “apt to be adduced where there is a difficult or impossible moral dilemma to be resolved” (153), precisely where other African societies might invoke matrilineal witchcraft (Ashanti), ancestral ghosts (Ndembu), lineage sorcery (Zulu), or spirit attack (Hausa). The Tallensi thus serve as a prime example of the limitations of a study of witchcraft as an approach to evil, precisely by showing not its absence but how it reappears in a different cultural pattern that is equally critical to understanding morality.

Clyde Kluckhohn’s account of Navajo witchcraft makes a different kind of statement from a different culture area and a different line of anthropological thinking. My intuition is that Kluckhohn’s book is less referenced as a classic than Evans-Pritchard’s not only because it is less appealing from a literary standpoint but because it is less accessible from the standpoint of discussing rationality, and frankly scarier from the standpoint of evil supernaturalism. Navajo witchcraft comprises “all types of malevolent activities which endeavor to control the outcome of events by supernatural techniques” (1944:22). Navajo witches are associated with death and incest; use powder made from human corpses and shoot mystical arrows into a victim; travel by night transformed into were-animals by clothing themselves in an animal skin; meet other witches to perform inverted versions of healing ceremonies; perpetrate sorcery through spells uttered over the victim’s clothing, a fabricated image of the victim, or bodily leavings like hair or fingernails; “pray a person into the ground” body part by body part; and perform love magic by administering hallucinogenic plants, including datura. They become witches “in order to wreak vengeance, in order to gain wealth or simply to injure wantonly—most often motivated by envy” (26), and must kill a close relative as part of their initiation. A witch who was caught could be killed.

The Navajo case is complicated by ethnographic uncertainty over whether one is dealing only with witchcraft “beliefs” or actual “practices.” There is also a fundamental ambivalence insofar as these practices were not necessarily evil when practiced by the divine Holy People in mythological times, and that traditional ceremonialists may be schooled both in sacred rituals and in methods of witchcraft. A distinguished chanter of my acquaintance once shocked me by acknowledging the ability to don an animal pelt and transform himself into a “skinwalker,” continuing on to avow the technique’s value in his day job as a police officer because having that ability “scared the daylights out of criminals” who knew he could immediately recapture them on attempted escape. For Kluckhohn, the emphasis was on positive and negative effects of witchcraft as a cultural pattern assemblage both with respect to the survival of Navajo society and the equilibrium of Navajo individuals, with the methodological injunction to resist an ethnocentric labeling of witchcraft and sorcery as “evil” (68). Witchcraft thus has a number of functions including to provide stories with entertainment value, to explain the inexplicable, to gain attention for oneself, to express culturally disallowed impulses and aggression, to deal with anxieties about subsistence, health, and deprivation due to pressures from contemporary white society as well as the lingering trauma of collective incarceration at Fort Sumner and the removal of intertribal warfare as an outlet for aggression—all of which “make for personal insecurity and for intensification of inter-personal conflicts” (87). Witches are scapegoats toward whom Navajos can vent hostility against relatives and whites to achieve “hate satisfaction,” comparable to the way other societies have blamed “Jews” or “niggers” [note that Kluckhohn was writing before Navajos elaborated their own race prejudice]. Witchcraft remains significant as a versatile expressive medium because other culturally developed patterns including withdrawal, passivity, conciliation, and narcoticism are insufficient to deal with and channel fundamental aggression and anxiety (92). A great adaptive advantage is that Navajo witches are often distant and thus anonymous rather than located within the immediate social group and readily identifiable, which moderates the degree of actual conflict. Moreover, with respect to morality, “witchcraft lore affirms solidarity by dramatically defining what is bad” (110); it prevents undue accumulation of wealth by those who fear jealousy, puts a check on the power and influence of ceremonial practitioners, and is a means of social control against “acting mean” and in favor of social cooperation.

It is not only the functional approach that allows Kluckhohn to defer judgment on evil in relation to witchcraft. Like Fortes, Kluckhohn provides a psychoanalytically inflected accounting for the particular character of witchcraft in terms of the effect of early childhood socialization on the psychological makeup of individuals. Rather than the effect being due to the balance of matrilineal and patrilineal forces on identity development as in the Tallensi and Ashanti cases, among the more individualistic Navajo it has instead to do with tensions between siblings since a child experiences a

dramatic removal of parental gratification when a younger child is born, and with the ambivalence toward old people who are closer to death and to becoming dangerous ghosts. This kind of psychological account affects both authors’ understandings of the relation of witchcraft to evil.

A rather different manner of deferring the question of evil appears in Geschiere’s (1997) work on southern Cameroon, where from the beginning it is clear that witchcraft/sorcery “was not just something evil to the people among whom I lived but that it also meant thrill, excitement, and the possibility of access to unknown powers” (1). Witchcraft is an idiom of power with a public presence in political practice and explicitly entwined in commodified contemporary culture.¹² Geschiere argues that the use of European-derived terms like witchcraft and sorcery creates a bias toward “unequivocal opposition between good and evil” where a more nuanced distinction taking into account a more fundamental ambiguity is required (12–13). He prefers beginning with local concepts of *djambe* or *evu*, the little being residing in the belly that is the source of a witch’s power, which as elsewhere serves to explain misfortune, contributes simultaneously to the leveling of inequalities and accumulation of power and wealth, and indeed constitutes “the dark side of kinship” now applied to the expanded scale of politics. Using the indigenous terms assists in raising analysis to an amoral level in the sense of suspending judgment, in specific contrast to the moralizing tenor and preoccupation with the micropolitics of social order that dominated British studies of witchcraft in the 1950s and 1960s. Thus the forces of witchcraft “have highly disturbing effects, but they can also be used constructively” (13); they are “inherently evil yet also a condition for all forms of success” (63); it is regrettable that they exist but they are indispensable to the proper functioning of society, and witchcraft “is in principle an evil force, yet it must be canalized and used for constructive aims in order to make society work” (219).

This ambiguity is raised to an ultimate degree in Stroeken’s (2010) work on the moral power of witchcraft and healing among the Sukuma of Tanzania. Here the witch is in fact “hyper-moral” and partakes of the same entitlement as the ancestor: “Both witch and cursing ancestor are thought to feel neglected, jealous of the other’s good fortune. Both have moral power in relation to the victim” (x). This moral power, derived from the dark side of kinship, operates according to a rationality specifying that because of some offense or neglect “the witch must be entitled to the victim’s life” (15). Hence the witch can override and pervert ancestral protection in order to “eat” the accursed victim. Witches are both socially marginal and intimately connected to their victims, such that

12. Certainly the modernity of witchcraft is no more the case in garrulous West Africa than among the more guarded Navajo, where I have observed the wearing of anti-witchcraft amulets, quietly and without comment, by staff members in a hospital psychiatric unit during a period of particularly stressful relations among their colleagues, and where I have been told that witchcraft is increasingly common as more Navajo become educated and successful.

"The absolute outside furnishes power; the absolute inside furnishes morality. Together they constitute the moral power the witch draws on . . . It is a type of power beyond domestication" (124). In this context the radical reality is that accused witches are in fact killed remarkably often, and at the same time an outcome of healing is often "to leave participants with a feeling kept largely unspoken: 'Aren't we all witches?'" (31).

Beyond this sampling of monographic treatments of witchcraft, I can only briefly allude to the tenor in relation to evil in a limited selection of edited collections. The volume edited by Kapferer (2002) stands firmly on the shoulders of Evans-Pritchard in beginning with and moving beyond the problem of rationality. One direction of this movement is emphasis on the "human-centric, person-centered and social nature of witchcraft's practical reason that gives prime force to human agency" (7), and the assertion that "Sorcery fetishizes human agency, often one which it magically enhances, as the key mediating factor affecting the course or direction of human life-chances" (105).¹³ Another is the conjunction of witchcraft and sorcery with the conditions of modernism, postmodernism, the state, and postcoloniality, pushing analysis toward mythopoesis, metacosmology, and the imaginary rather than toward morality, while yet acknowledging their inherent violence and the monstrosity of their symbolism and practice. In contrast to this approach, the volume edited by Whitehead and Wright (2004) on witchcraft and sorcery practiced by "dark shamans" in Amazonia directly confronts both the lethal violence and socio-cosmological centrality of these practices. This strategy avoids playing into either a renewal of irrationalizing colonial demonization in the name of suppression or romanticizing contemporary rehabilitation in the name of cultural diversity. Thus, Amazonian shamanism is a "predatory animism," and in this sense its key symbol of the jaguar should be understood not as an endangered species but as a dangerous predator (Fausto 2004:171). The witch or dark shaman is "the embodiment of evil in the world" because they "lack empathy for other humans and act for purely personal motives" (Heckenberger 2004:179). For the Arara people there are explicit connections among morality, sorcery, and banishment with respect to people who forgo generosity and unselfishness and thereby "break the moral rules connected to the use of certain technical skills" (Texeira-Pinto 2004:217).

The collection edited by Walker (1989) focusing primarily on indigenous peoples of the Americas encompasses diversity among them by broadly defining witchcraft and sorcery as "the aggressive use of supernatural techniques" (3). Individual victims suffer from anxiety over being the target of hate or envy, and techniques reflect culturally patterned fears and

frustrations. The emphasis is on functional interpretation at both the individual and social level, though with a recognition of violence as a theme and the declaration that "By investigating the aggressive and even immoral uses of religion and magic, we may explore the darker and uncontrollable side of human nature" (9). In contrast, the volume edited by Ter Haar (2007) on African witchcraft from a predominantly religious studies perspective foregrounds the problem of evil. The possibility is entertained that in the contemporary milieu "not just the human world but the spirit world *itself* has gone out of control," and that contemporary witches represent a situation in which the spirit world has "assumed and inherently evil character in the face of which humans are rather powerless" (2). While witchcraft accusations are understood to result in serious violation of human rights, witchcraft beliefs amount to a moral theory, and witchcraft is defined as "a manifestation of evil believed to come from a human source" (8) with powers "considered to be inherent, voluntary, and permanent" (11).

Several other collections could be included in this discussion,¹⁴ but I have examined enough of this work to make several general remarks about the contribution of witchcraft to grounding a study of evil and morality. Bond and Ciekawy (2001) state the overall situation as clearly as anyone:

It [witchcraft] is not the quirk of one people but, one might suggest, an attempt to explain events and activities, to account for misfortunes through a projection of human agency. It involves economic, political, and moral issues. It

14. A volume edited by Moore and Sanders (2001) includes an introduction that offers a comprehensive analysis of the extensive body of anthropological literature on African witchcraft since Evans-Pritchard, the surface of which I have barely been able to scratch in the present discussion. Several of the contributions directly address evil and misfortune (Rasmussen 2001) and morality (Sanders 2001; van Dijk 2001), while Moore and Sanders in their introduction highlight the ambivalence of witchcraft in relation to both morality and modernity. A contemporaneous volume edited by Bond and Ciekawy (2001) on witchcraft in Africa with contributions primarily by philosophers and anthropologists takes up morality and ethics and on occasion directly addresses evil but for the most part adopts a similar concern with the broader meaning of witchcraft. The volume edited by Stephen (1987) on witchcraft and sorcery in Melanesia is singularly concerned with bringing scholarship from that geographical region out from under the theoretical and ethnographic shadow of Africanist scholarship. With such a goal, the theme of evil is peripheral to issues of cosmology, politics, religion, warfare, social change, legitimate uses of sorcery, and the validity of a distinction between sorcery and witchcraft. Likewise, the volume on witchcraft and sorcery in Southeast Asia edited by Watson and Ellen (1993) also sets itself off against Africanist scholarship but does so more by observing the different colonial circumstances that resulted in these practices being both less frequently reported and less of an overt social problem than in Africa, as well as a scholarly problematic more related to the diagnosis and curing of sickness than to rationality and social control, and the effect of relations with major religious traditions in addition to Christianity (Islam, Buddhism, and Hinduism). Here evil is explicitly recognized as a topic, primarily with reference to different degrees of evil attributed to witches and sorcerers in societies across the region, and to the relation between evil and power.

13. Kapferer's introduction includes a lucid comparison of witchcraft and sorcery, including the observation that witchcraft is immoral because of its unambiguous malevolence, while sorcery is amoral because of its ambiguous possibilities for both protection and destruction (11).

is full of surprises and imaginary reversals revealing the moral order through its symbolic representation of the images of both the good and the bad person. The imagined world of witches is essential to maintaining the moral and ethical order of the real world of everyday experiences. (2001:5)

In this and other accounts, the problem of evil is sometimes deferred but never erased. The origins of a sensibility for evil and its place within a particular cultural configuration may be psychoanalytically inflected or subordinated to social structural considerations, but it is never explained away. The moral status of power remains ambiguous, and the figure of the witch may be inherently ambivalent, but evil is simply evil when power is used for evil ends by a witch with evil motives. Evil is neither a category imposed as a condition of colonization by Christian civilization nor a Christian category distorting anthropological interpretation, but one of the conditions of possibility for the discourse of witchcraft to count as moral discourse.

An Irony of Evil: Child Witchcraft

We can make one more pass over the terrain of witchcraft, however, to offer a specific cross-cultural example of how taking account of evil might contribute to an anthropological approach to morality. This reflection originates with the recent observation by Jenkins (2013) that in contemporary Zuni society witchcraft remains a problem, that moreover some witches are children, and that it appeared that the witches were becoming younger all the time. There is evidence that even in earlier times it was known that a Zuni child could decide to learn witchcraft (Ellis 1989:196), but the idea that children might not only require protection from witchcraft but also be accused of it is disturbing. Unfortunately, the Zuni are not unique. The idea of child witchcraft appears to have been introduced to the subarctic Athabaskan Kaska around the turn of the twentieth century, whereupon a pattern of witch-killing ensued in which a child was blamed for someone's serious illness and often "confessed to the crime which he did not understand" (Honigsmann 1989:29). Harsh punishment and execution of child witches was common among Arawak-speaking peoples of the Peruvian Amazon until around 1970 (following mass conversions to Christianity) but resurfaced in the 1990s in the context of intense political violence; the accused do not protest their innocence because they feel that the accusation itself constitutes proof regardless of their intentions or awareness of any occult powers (Santos-Granero 2004). In the past several years an epidemic of child witchcraft in Africa has been reported both in the scholarly literature (de Boeck 2005; Ranger 2007) and in popular press reports from the Congo (Dowden 2006; Harris 2009) and the Niger Delta in Nigeria (Harrison 2008; Houreld 2009). Children are subjected to brutal exorcisms, abandoned to the streets, or murdered, often by pastors in the name of fun-

damentalist Christianity. Again, children "can be persuaded to accept it's their fault. They tell themselves 'it is me, I am evil'" (Remy Mafu quoted by Dowden 2006:2).¹⁵

Are Euro-American societies immune from this phenomenon? There were indeed episodes of child witchcraft in seventeenth- and eighteenth-century Europe associated with the emergence of childhood as a cultural category and revealing not only a dark side to the history of childhood but "a move from one symbolic organization, from one way of understanding evil, to another" (Roper 2000:109). Much closer culturally and historically, in the contemporary United States, I would argue to include instances like the killing in 2010 of a 7-year-old girl and the severe injury of her 11-year-old sister—both coincidentally adopted from Liberia—by parents adherent to the Independent Fundamental Baptist sect who customarily carried out "spiritual spanking" on all their children, based on a widely promulgated interpretation of the biblical injunction derived from the aphorism "spare the rod and spoil the child" (Harris 2010). This is strikingly analogous to the cases of child witchcraft in Africa. Granted that torture, abandonment, and/or killing as punishment for alleged witchery is not precisely the same as an intent to beat children into docility in order to suppress a tendency toward evil, with death as an unintended outcome. This is only to say that the overt forms taken by these nominally Christian practices vary culturally from North America to Africa. The presumption of children not as victims but as perpetrators of evil is what is at question, revealing the deep irony of a twisted logic that enables killing in the name of destroying evil in someone whose only experience of evil is in the beating itself.

Cycling once more back to Africa, consider the following from an *ABC Nightline* account of child witchcraft in Congo. Having investigated four churches in which it was common for children to be accused of witchcraft and subjected to harsh deliverance or exorcism ceremonies, the journalists

took our evidence directly to a senior government official, Theodore Luleka Mwanalwamba, who heads a special commission to protect children, including those accused of witchcraft in the Congo. He said it's illegal to accuse a child of witchcraft—unless you have proof. The government official explained that witchcraft is part of the country's traditional belief system. He says it's possible for a child to be a witch, "if a child has big eyes, black eyes or a bulging tummy." (Harris and Karamehmedovic 2009:3)

At the very least, this account offers a clear opportunity to distinguish between cultural and moral relativism. In the first instance it is possible to recognize that in one system of cultural meaning black eyes and a bulging tummy may identify one as a witch, while in another they may indicate kwashi-orkor, and indeed these accounts may be construed so as not

15. This discussion is not intended to occlude the fact that women in Africa have been and continue to be frequent targets of witchcraft accusation and murder (Adinkrah 2004; Field 1960).

to contradict one another. In the second instance the two interpretations of these signs can be morally reconciled only by arguing either that malnutrition leads children to witchcraft or that child witches become malnourished as a consequence of their activities, and that otherwise they are radically incommensurable. Beyond relativism, if evil has a place, a locus, in the analysis of this statement, it is not so much in the obliviousness to structural violence that engenders malnutrition, nor is it in the malevolence of street children, but in the profoundly ironic symbolic violence whereby symptoms of affliction are transformed into signs of evil intent. This is not to say that Mr. Mwanalwamba is an evil man, or that he is speaking on behalf of an evil government. Evil is the social and rhetorical condition of possibility for this symbolic violence—not an attribute of any actor but of human imagination itself—and perhaps the most existentially valid ground for a critique of moral relativism.

Conclusion

Let me reiterate that the preceding discussion is not motivated by an interest in witchcraft per se, or in evil for its own sake, but by the question of an anthropological approach to morality. To recognize that such an approach must confront the enigma of evil as a human phenomenon is not to say that we should return to a study of witchcraft as our starting point but that we take seriously along with Parkin that “Evil is morality reflecting on itself” (1985a:242). When we do reconsider witchcraft, we will see it not simply in terms of the sociology of accusation or traditional practices of cursing and spell-casting but as an instance of a human phenomenon that an anthropological approach to morality remains obligated to theorize. Cases like those of child witchcraft in which evil is perpetrated in the name of eradicating evil poignantly raise the question of whether one can be evil or involved in evil without knowing it. This question constitutes a wide category of phenomena that ranges across the acknowledgment of unwitting harm done that exculpates the Zande witch and the standard operating procedures of military personnel operating as part of the security apparatus at Abu Ghraib prison, the moral lacunae of the sociopath and the moral depravity of the psychopath, the delusion of not recognizing evil (Anakin Skywalker becoming Darth Vader) and the denial of compromising with it (Dr. Jekyll becoming Mr. Hyde). The priest/ethnographer De Rosny (1981) recognizes this disturbing existential category in his work on *nganga* healers in Duala, describing evil sorcerers as “either people who manipulate others’ credulity for their own profit (sometimes even using poison); or persons who are not conscious of their own perversity. . . . Aren’t there in every society certain perverted persons who—without even knowing it—make their fellow men ill by draining their vital energy from them, thus depersonalizing them—in other words ‘eating’ them?” (quoted in and translated by Geschiere 1997:20).

We will also have to consider the fact that in those instances

where the focus comes to be on the victims of witchcraft, the register shifts to that of ethnopsychiatry and medical anthropology. This is the case in Field’s (1960) study of Ashanti women’s self-accusations of witchcraft corresponding to depressive disorder;¹⁶ Favret-Saada’s (1980) case study of a bewitched French man whom she encountered in a psychiatric hospital; and Levy, Neutra, and Parker’s (1987) examination of Navajo frenzy witchcraft in relation to epilepsy and other seizure disorders. The consequences for our theorizing are that the discussion must then account for the relation between morality and pathology. In any case, the study of morality must take up the problem of evil, and one of evil’s primary loci is witchcraft. It is not a mere curiosity that the Hopi used to say that “there may be more witches than normal persons in a village” (Ellis 1989:196). Neither is it meaningless that despite there being among the Navajo numerous named forms of witchcraft (Kluckhohn 1944), Navajos also recognize that merely thinking or speaking negatively can bring about harm. Indeed, insofar as witchcraft is a human disposition—another name for malevolence and disregard and a phenomenon of concern to homodicy rather than theodicy—it may in some degree exist even in societies where it remains unnamed and unelaborated.

Beyond what we have been able to learn by a reconsideration of witchcraft, the investigation just concluded entitles us, or perhaps obligates us, to ask whether the notion of evil can or should constitute an analytic category, not to abet the study of evil for its own sake but as part of an anthropological approach to morality. The problem of evil reminds us that the issue is not exhausted by the question of how people decide what is right and wrong, since it is possible not to care at all about that. In gesturing toward an ethic of evil, there are two general ways in which such a category could be defined. As a cumulative category, evil would be either the sum total or the least common denominator of all the indigenous concepts and situations that ethnology could assemble, though as with any such category this strategy would face the problems of contextual commensurability and where to draw its boundaries. As a substantive category, evil would require an essential structure sufficiently flexible to avoid the universalism and immutability of essentialism while facilitating description of essences of the particular.

Thus, for example, we might propose that the depravity and malevolence that constitute evil be defined along two dimensions. The first would identify its source as internal or external in the sense of originating in the human or the diabolical. Are human actors affected by evil as victim or perpetrator, prey or predator, as the motive of action or the consequence of action by others? This distinction requires presupposing a valence of moral responsibility that problematizes both the claim that “the devil made me do it” and

16. For a recent reconsideration of M. J. Field’s classic study of depression and witchcraft self-accusation in the context of social justice, see Jenkins (2013).

confronts the dilemma of whether it is possible to be or do evil without knowing it. The second would identify its mode as active or passive in the broad sense, in which the behavioral manifestation of the former is the positive malevolence of violence and abuse, with the associated moral emotion of hatred and moral stance of hostility, and in which the behavioral manifestation of the latter is the negative malevolence of disregard and neglect, with the associated moral emotion of self-love and moral stance of narcissism. This distinction requires presupposing a qualitative difference between actions such as assault, dispossession, displacement, debasement, or enslavement on the one hand and lack of care, abandonment, delegitimization, and failure to recognize on the other.¹⁷

All these questions deserve a place on the agenda as we determine the ethnographic and theoretical place of morality in contemporary anthropology. This brings us back finally to the question of whether indeed it is necessary or valuable to understand morality as a "cultural system." Recall that Geertz's intent was to identify systems of cultural symbols as distinct from social forces and psychological motives operating in those domains. The cultural systems he mentions include religion, ideology, science, common sense, and art (1973, 1975, 1976), so our question is whether morality can be placed among them. If a religion as a cultural system is "a cluster of sacred symbols, woven into some kind of ordered whole" (1973:129), and ideologies are to be examined "as systems of interacting symbols, as patterns of interworking meanings" (207), can the same be said of a morality? Perhaps on this level a society's moral system is undergirded by a selection of symbolic oppositions such as good/bad, good/evil, right/wrong, virtue/vice.¹⁸ Perhaps these oppositions generate metaphorical equivalents such as white/black, lightness/darkness, above/below; inflect experiential states such as pleasure/pain, love/hate, health/illness; define social categories such as human rights and human trafficking, existential states such as salvation and damnation, and mythical figures such as deity and demon or saint and witch. Before one objects that this formulation appears too dualistic, note that it cannot be dichotomous categories in themselves that are objectionable, since the very idea of moral choice or judgment and ethical decision or dilemma presume at least two options. If good/bad or good/evil seem problematic, are good/better or good/not-as-good more satisfactory? Emphasizing the latter may appear to be opting for a Classical as opposed to a

Christian (or Abrahamic) moral sensibility, but it may also be construed as preferring an elitist ethics where one has the leisure to pursue the good without getting one's hands dirtied by the bad or the evil. Neither do generative symbolic oppositions preclude gray areas of moral ambiguity, morally ambivalent motives, degrees of goodness and badness, combinations of some good and some bad, or multiple ethical alternatives in concrete situations.¹⁹

There is an important way, however, in which morality is distinct from the cultural systems identified by Geertz. The distinction between religion in general and specific religions, for example, differs from that between morality and moralities. One cannot be outside morality in the way one can be outside religion (moral indifference is a moral stance, religious indifference is simply indifference to religion), for morality is distributed across cultural systems, institutional domains, and situations of practical action. Moreover, on a pragmatic level the increasing coalescence of a global social system brings moral alternatives into direct contact in a single arena (child witchcraft, female circumcision, human rights, global climate change, global financial crisis, population movements, genocidal violence, epidemics). Across localities within the global social system, symbolic oppositions such as those I have just outlined may be more or less elaborated in practice and awareness, with the possibility of one pole of an opposition receiving greater attention than the other. Unlike religion, science, and art, morality has no institutional structures unique to itself, and in this it is perhaps closest to common sense. Yet the stakes of common sense and morality are different; someone without common sense may be described as a fool but not as evil, and the kind of negligence attributable to a fool cannot be of the same order of destructiveness as that attributable to a perpetrator of evil.

Put somewhat differently, cultural systems like religion, ideology, science, common sense, and aesthetics may interact and even overlap, but morality is uniquely distributed across them all. This is already evident in Geertz, for whom in religion the mutual confirmation of ethos and worldview both "objectivizes moral and aesthetic preferences by depicting them as the imposed conditions of life" and "supports these received beliefs about the world's body by invoking deeply felt moral and aesthetic sentiments" (1973:90). Moreover, ideology is at least in part a matter of "beliefs to which they [people] attach great moral significance" (195). The critical feature of morality from an anthropological standpoint is thus not its systemic properties, because in fact it may be better conceived as a modality of action in any domain—a flavor, a moment, a valence, an atmosphere, a dimension of human action that may be more or less pronounced, more or less vividly dis-

17. In response to an early presentation of these dimensions, two colleagues suggested that they might usefully generate a two by two table of categories, qualifying with the remark that "we're sociologists" and thereby predisposed to such tables. It is not a bad idea, but I will not pursue it further here.

18. The repertoire can be expanded: moral/immoral, moral/amoral, kindness/cruelty, care/neglect, presence/abandonment, creation/destruction, nurturance/violence, etc. Analysis based on such oppositions can, moreover, be more properly semantic as well as symbolic. This is the case in Anna Wierzbicka's (1996) analyses that attempt to identify semantic universals including oppositions such as good/bad.

19. Even the concept of the amoral includes a binary element insofar as it can pertain to a situation in which morality is deemed irrelevant or a situation in which morality is ignored.

cernible, and more or less urgent across settings and situations but always present whenever humans are present.²⁰

To summarize, consideration of evil is necessary if an anthropological approach to morality is to be complete and comprehensive; arraying evil along dimensions of internal/external and passive/active may provide a more systematic way for it to operate as an analytic category; and approaching morality in terms of symbolic oppositions such as those between good and evil may provide a framework for cross-cultural analysis. None of this, however, obligates us to treat morality as a cultural system in Geertz's sense, as a coherent system of symbols that can potentially sustain an institutional order. In this respect we ought to be wary insofar as treating morality as a noun creates a semantic milieu that rhetorically moves us toward thinking of it as an entified cultural system or domain to be placed alongside religion, ideology, law, or politics. The move to pluralize the noun as "moralities" is a valuable hedge that helps guarantee pluralism across cultures and internal diversity within, keeping the issues of relativism and variation before us. However, this move does not invite us to analyze morality as a modality of being in the way we might by instead emphasizing how we use "moral" as an adjective that can precede and modify any number of terms: obligation, challenge, sensibility, emotion, crisis, failing, code, system, education, community, judgment, order, actor. In the adjectival rather than its nominal sense it may be easier to recognize that the moral can enter into—spontaneously or by conscious evocation—virtually any corner of human concern.

Acknowledgments

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20. I made this suggestion in the panel discussion at the 2010 AAA meeting and subsequently found that it was at the same moment coming into print in a work by Michael Lambek, who warns against trying to make an anthropology of ethics into another disciplinary subfield, insofar as "The task is to recognize the ethical dimension of human life—of the human condition—without objectifying ethics as a natural organ of society, universal category of human thought, or distinct kind of human practice. In sum, it is preferable to see the ethical as a modality of social action or of being in the world than as a modular component of society or mind. . . . Rather than attempting to locate and specify a domain of ethics, we ought to clarify and deepen our understanding of the ethical quality of the full range of human action and practice" (2010:10, 11). I quite agree with this stance.

Comments

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Anthropologists tend to avoid speaking of evil. This may be partly due to the use of a disturbing political rhetoric of Othering by politicians. More significantly, as Pickering pointed out in regard to the status of the concept of evil in Durkheim's sociology, "contemporary[ies] dislike . . . language that implies theological and metaphysical overtones" (Pickering and Rosati 2008, 169). In his elegantly composed argument, Csordas unties the concept of evil from theodicy in general and Christian connotations in particular by suggesting an alternative theory of evil based on "homodicity" or "ethnodicity" manifesting in concrete, situated human actions. To eschew engaging with "evil" does not help to solve the problem of how to account for morality (or moralities) and ensuing dilemmas created by cultural and moral relativism. Csordas offers a highly original approach to consider such issues in a new light.

This approach goes beyond the Durkheimian distinction between positive and negative dimensions of the social or the uneasy transposition of the notion of "evil" into a problem of translation. In French, Pickering pointed out "le mal" denotes a fusion of theological evil with (secular) suffering (physical and mental pain). The meaning has to be derived from the context of the use of the word (9). The associations implied in the French word "mal," however, have to be carefully disassembled in an anthropological theorization of morality. By starting off from one of the core concerns of anthropology, witchcraft, and sorcery, and a fresh reading of these ethnographic accounts with a focus on morality, Csordas establishes evil as an analytic category facilitating cross-cultural understanding of human experiences related to destructive emotions, acts, and practices. In my view this move is particularly useful because it allows not only for the cross-cultural analysis of the relationships between evil and morality but also for those of differently named instances of human malevolence, of harm, hatred, violence, abuse, destructiveness, aggression, etc., in social and cultural circumstances that are often treated separately in terms of history, culture, or politics.

As an analytic category, evil needs to be understood in terms of qualitative distinctions between victims and perpetrators, social actors targeted as "motive" or "consequence" of the actions of others, active infliction of pain or passive suffering of afflictions. However, as the cases of child witchcraft considered by Csordas demonstrate, the practical logic of evil may blur or twist the clear positioning of "victim" and "perpetrator" when the "sign of affliction" is transposed into a "sign of evil." Do witchcraft and sorcery thus provide a

kind of key for theorizing the role of evil as situated human activity more generally, as Csordas suggests? Or is the practical logic of evil also discernible in violent human encounters framed in other moral terms? Such as, for example, in the recent revelations about the activities of a Neo-Nazi group in Germany responsible for the brutal killings of nine men with a Turkish immigrant background, all of them owners of a family business, over the last decade? One of the reasons for the apparent incapacity of the German police to solve the case for years does indeed seem to depend on the twisted logic turning the signs of affliction into signs of (potential) evil. The police categorically excluded the possibility of right-wing xenophobic motives from the start and assumed instead that the murders must be either motivated by cultural sentiments (honor killings) or by crimes attributed predominantly to “foreigners” (drug and human trafficking). A book written by the daughter of one of the victims vividly describes the destructive effects of how being suspected as a perpetrator when one experiences loss, damage, and suffering because of—in this instance—racial hatred generate illness on a personal level, suspicion and distrust on the collective one, as well as an overall feeling of injustice. The case is, of course, more complex than I could allude to it here.

By reconceptualizing the notion of evil and insisting that without it morality makes no sense, Csordas has offered an innovative approach to understand the common ground of witchcraft, racial hatred, xenophobia, rape, and other instances of human violence. If the “moral” is to be understood as a modality of social action rather than as a “cultural system,” the same should apply to “evil.” In the contemporary world shaped by the juxtaposition of diverse moralities in a single arena, as those maintained by the German police and Turkish immigrants, the moral values of one group may become reinterpreted as the stereotypical evil of another. This situation complicates cross-cultural analysis undertaken from a cultural relativist angle; the familiar problem of the nature of the relationships between asymmetrical constellations of power, morality, and the construal of evil poses a new challenge to anthropology when evil is stripped from its meta-physical overtones and transposed into human phenomena.

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Recognizing the impossibility of addressing in a few hundred words the many issues that Thomas Csordas raises in this important article, I will simply ask questions that seem relevant to it.

- 1) Is it possible to distinguish an anthropology of morality from moral anthropology? Would any anthropology be moral, if it did not include an anthropology of morality?

- 2) Although Csordas notes a long, if sporadic, concern for the moral dimension of social existence in anthropology, he fails to recognize that moral anthropology has often deflected the ethnographic study of morality, including that of the anthropologist. We know the—by now over-rehearsed—moral dilemmas of doing fieldwork. But, how often have anthropologists considered them in terms of their informant’s morality? How often have I heard (American) anthropologists insist on establishing an egalitarian relationship with the people they work with without asking whether their informants want such a relationship? Does this insistence refract (unwittingly, one hopes) America’s dogged attempt to impose its style of democracy on others?
- 3) Is the distinction philosophers make between descriptive and normative morality as clear as they take it to be? They assume that the claims of normative morality are universal and are, in consequence, troubled by problems of relativity. But is the link between the normative and the universal secure? Normative assumptions may be restricted, wittingly or unwittingly, to a particular group—a tribe, community, or class. Or there may be total indifference to questions of universality. *What’s moral for me may not be moral for others. We have our ways, and they have theirs. So be it.* The recognition of moral difference does not necessarily entail questions of moral relativity.
 - a) What are the social conditions that inspire the universalist claims of (our) normative morality?
 - b) We have to recognize that universalist claims, whatever their rationalization, serve rhetorical—and political—ends. We have also to acknowledge that our moralizing attitudes toward rhetoric can mask the rhetoric of the universal.
- 4) Moral reflection, however logically or mechanically laid out, rests on a self-descriptive morality, which, given our involvement, is never transparent, rationalization-free, or immune to rhetorical effect.
 - a) I suggest that the prevalent idiom in American self—and social—understanding focuses on the moral and not the political (which, à la Rancière, has to be distinguished from politics). If my observation is correct, then the discursive priority given the moral affects the way we conceptualize the moral dimension of other societies.
 - b) Our *psychological* idiom affects and is affected by our moral one. It often substitutes for—recodes—it. Their relationship is neither symmetrical nor reciprocal.
- 5) We have to question both our and our informants’ meta-moral understanding and evaluation.
- 6) Csordas’s argument that the moral—morality—cannot be subsumed by Geertz’s *x-as-a-cultural-system* approach to socio-cultural reality is, in my view, well taken. But, is Geertz’s approach a worthy foil for Csordas’s argument? Can it also be applied to Geertz’s approach to religion, ideology, and other “systems”? Were we to consider the

spiritual (whatever that may mean) as an essential component of religiosity, the spiritual would then be analogous to the moral.

The position or nonposition of the *spiritual* is similar to that of *evil* in anthropological discourse. Their effacement—the absence they leave—is perhaps more determinative of that discourse than their presence would have been.

- 7) Is a notion of evil, however understood, essential to moral understanding and evaluation? Most of our moral conflicts have little to do with evil—or even the good and the bad. They are, for the most part, petty. Evil, if it is invoked, may simply be rhetorical. Or, it may serve as an (empty, though potent) organizing principle for the elaboration of moral-evaluative hierarchies and the judgments they entail.
 - a) Does the reification of evil blind us to the dynamics—the rhetoric—of evil?
 - b) Does the gothic characterization of evil—think of Csordas's discussion of witchcraft—empower the rhetoric of evil?
- 8) Csordas's dualistic understanding of moral conflict oversimplifies the problem of moral choice. There are often more than two choices. What may be of ethnographic interest is how and under what circumstances are moral choices reduced to two, if indeed they are.
- 9) Are the instigators of evil—demons and devils—necessarily evil? Does a predisposition to judge people and the acts they perpetrate—the conditions they create—as either good or bad, evil or not evil, blind us to the role of the amoral and moral indifference in the constitution of morality?
- 10) Might an anthropology of the amoral—amorality—and moral indifference be conceptually and indeed morally more revealing of the bleaker side of human consociation? But, then, we might be led to consider the amoral and the morally indifferent side of anthropological research.

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If you want to study happiness, then start with misery. Similarly, the entry points for a study of morality are its negative aspects, of which the most salient is evil. Csordas's scholarly and thought-provoking article builds significantly on this claim. He precludes the essentialization of morality as a cultural system by embedding it in those human actions that are seen locally to violate moral expectations. So morality does not exist as a cultural system but, in adjectival mode, qualifies and pervades all human social activity.

Csordas asserts that it is only by confronting evil as an anthropological problem that we can address how morality is culturally inflected. As he says, "if it wasn't for evil morality would be moot." In other words, the boundaries of the positive are predicated on the definitional challenges of the negative, a procedural principle that I have found persuasive. This point obviates the need to hover indefinitely over questions of whether evil is only ever culturally defined. We already know this. But, like the fact of death clouded by its many cultural interpretations, evil is existentially present even if not amenable to set identification, an apparent elusiveness that has deterred many anthropologists from considering it a proper subject for analysis.

Here Csordas advances what I see as his boldest and most contentious proposition, namely, that witchcraft is a "concrete activity . . . prerequisite to formulating an anthropological approach to morality." In noting that I did not see witchcraft as having a privileged place among the many perspectives on evil and virtue, he persuasively argues that witchcraft does in fact lend itself most directly to what he earlier calls a human and intersubjective level of analysis of evil and thence of morality. In other words, demons, angry gods, and natural disasters are not necessarily less evil from the viewpoint of sufferers but do not inform the agency of humans such as witches who flout and so define morality through their apparently evil acts.

Csordas's stress on the analysis of humanly commissioned evil as the route to understanding morality is justified. However, I also see it as modified by instances of human culpability being displaced onto nonhuman agents, thereafter regarded as responsible for the evil. Csordas cites Kapferer's observation that, while Sinhalese regard sorcery as immoral, it is displaced onto demons ("supramundane agents"). But does such a process of displacement actually exonerate humans of their culpability, or is it another way of referring to human culpability within a wider sphere of alternating explanations, a kind of transposed or deferred moral blame? For instance, sickness or misfortune in many African communities may successively be attributed to spirits, impiety, broken prohibitions, ancestral negligence, and witches. That these many agents of alleged evil may alternate as explanations within a single case suggests a kind of equivalence between human and nonhuman agents, for example, spirits and witches standing in for each other. This further suggests that "our" notion of human culpability should be broadened to include its apparently nonhuman manifestations. We can see them all as a single human/trans-human discourse.

Csordas's claim for the privileged place of witchcraft holds to the extent that a people does identify witches as the unambiguously human inversion of normal morality that we call evil. But insofar as spirits and other nonhuman manifestations may sometimes be cited as part of a discourse on human culpability (nonhumans, like spirits, being an extension of humans), then the question of the centrality of witchcraft becomes an ontological question of what the boundaries

of humanity and of human witches are. Witches are people, but are they wholly so, especially when they take on non-human forms? And what about evil agents, such as spirits, who take on human form? In fieldwork it has been explained to me that “spirits are people” but that spirits are also different from people and more akin to animals. We can interpret both claims as metaphorical (spirits are like people or spirits are like animals). But that glosses over the fact that these may also be regarded as literal statements, true at the time of their enunciation, in the same way that some Christians assert that Christ was both human and divine at given points in his existence. So, taken together with the alternating attributions of evil to both nonhuman and human agents of evil, I suggest that we take ethnographic account in particular cases of fuzziness in the identification of human and nonhuman, and of human and nonhuman evil. Witches, like zombies, are or were human but sometimes take nonhuman form and so constitute an ambivalence that straddles the two dimensions. That said, Csordas provides the most sophisticated critique and agenda regarding the current anthropological interest in morality to appear in years.

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The Anthropology of Morality: Varieties of Morality and “Evil”

In his erudite and wide-ranging article, “Morality as a Cultural System?” Csordas explores the anthropology of morality by focusing on the anthropology of evil. His analysis combines emic and etic perspectives, and it extends to the morality of anthropological theory and practice. Avoiding (what he sees as reductive) Durkheimian functionalism and pragmatic neo-Marxist activism, he argues that morality does not form a cultural system. Nor, for that matter, do cultures—including those of academic anthropology—themselves form closed and static systems (Rorty 1994).

Csordas is surely right that morality—whether regarded as universal or as culturally variable—does not form a distinctive class of principles, institutions, practices, motives, or emotions. It is not—and does not form—a unified coherent system. It plays many distinct functions, capable of conflicting with one another; it has distinctive unstable allies and resistances. Given the polymorphous pluralism of “the” domain of morality, we might wonder whether—except in the constructions of reifying theorists or moralizing rhetoricians—there is an “it” there, a reified category composed of a coherent and rationalized set of prohibitions, duties, ideals.

Csordas is also surely right that attention to the dark side—to the anthropology of the violations of morality, to the pro-

hibited and the forbidden—can illuminate what is at stake in the theory and practices of morality. Given the wide range of concerns that Csordas finds in the theories and practices of morality, it is surprising that he focuses on “evil” as the primary default contrast. If morality disperses, its oppositional contrasts must surely also fragment.

Csordas’s skepticism about whether morality forms a unified cultural system can be substantiated by an anthropological case study of contemporary Anglo-American moral theory and practice. The various forms and concerns of “morality” can be distinguished as follows:

- 1) the minimal negative morality of prohibitions that define the domain of the forbidden;
- 2) the minimal positive morality of righteousness, the principles of justice, the obligations that define basic social roles and responsible agency;
- 3) the positive morality of decency: the norms of normality, mutuality, neighborliness, trust, cooperation, friendship as they model affectional relations;
- 4) the constructive ideals of virtue and excellence that set priorities.

These various moral concerns have distinctive “logics” and rationales; their expectations and sanctions differ; their prompting motives are disparate; their roles in regulating and structuring social and individual behavior vary. They can conflict with one another. Some are expressed in deontological terms; others are consequentialist in orientation; still others express aesthetic ideals (see Rorty 1992, 1996).

As “morality” expresses distinctive incommensurable concerns, so too do categories of what Csordas classifies as “evil.” Its varieties are historically, contextually, and semantically marked. The richness of the vocabulary—“abominations,” “disobedience,” “vice,” “malevolence,” “sin,” “wanton cruelty,” “immorality,” “corruption,” “harm,” “criminality,” “sociopathology”—indicate distinguishable conceptual domains. Each has its primary place in a specific outlook, with distinctive preoccupations and questions, theories of agency and responsibility (see Rorty 2001).

Some of the earliest forms of the generic notion of evil demarcate *abominations*—acts that, like incest, cannibalism, patricide—elicit horror and disgust. Abominations are violations, disorders of nature that issue in natural sanctions: plagues or expulsions. The world in which *evil* is construed as a form of *sinful disobedience* is a world defined by a divinity who gives commands, exacts obedience, punishes, or rewards (Genesis and Exodus). A world focused on virtue and *vice* is a naturalistic, social world (Theophrastus, Butler, Mandeville). Virtues are those traits that—like courage and justice—preserve and enhance a community. The vices—greed, disloyalty, envy, self-indulgence, disrespect—threaten the social order. The origins and sanctions for vices are social: an unfortunate upbringing in a malformed polity can issue in the kind of corruption whose sanction is the loss of trust and cooperation. With *malevolence* (Pope Innocent III, Calvin), we enter a new world, a world of individual will and responsibility. While

malevolence is normally marked by a defective will, *sin* fuses disobedience with a defiant will (Aquinas, Jonathan Edwards). But while the earliest forms of disobedience can be relatively innocent, *sin* presupposes that Everyman, in the full knowledge of the difference between good and evil, right and wrong, willfully violates the divine order by presumptuous pride (Milton's Satan, Goethe's Faust). When the disposition or proclivity to *sin*—construed as pride or egoism—becomes an inherently dominant and psychologically structuring motive, only divine grace can set aside divine punishment. Evil becomes less fraught when morality returns to the secular, social order during the Renaissance and Enlightenment. Setting aside the theology and metaphysics of *sin*, the new psychology turned to characterizing character traits that—like wanton cruelty—generate “man's inhumanity to man” (Montaigne, Voltaire). *Partiality*, *egoism*—the desire for glory or self-interest—remain primary human motives, part of the inescapable human condition, but they are naturalized, judiciously tempered by practical reason (Machiavelli, Hobbes, Mandeville). So formed, they are no longer sins: they are thought to serve, rather than impede, the social virtues. Once individual interests have been contrasted to the comprehensive general common good, rationality becomes the moral faculty. But it prompts the question: how is it possible for a rational being of good will to be *immoral* (Rousseau, Kant)? Following the Romantics' attack on the authority and the power of reason, the imagination is presented as fascinated by the sensuous lures of *corruption* (de Sade, Baudelaire). Traditional morality is radically reinterpreted (Blake, Nietzsche). Meanwhile, on the other side of the channel, the connection between morality and rationality swerves to an empirical calculation of the economy of benefits and *harms*. The terminology shifts from theology and philosophy to economics and law (Bentham and Mill). When, in an unexpected turn, *immorality* is classified as a species of psychological pathology, evil becomes *criminality* or *sociopathology*.

The guiding maxims of the morality of anthropology as a social practice have been adapted from the principles of medical and therapeutic ethics. “Above all, do no harm.” “Preserve autonomy.” “Treat the subject as a whole.” “Maintain trust.” “Honor the rights of privacy and informed consent.”²¹ What these maxims actually demand is neither clear nor determinate. In the face of familiar conflicts among their contestable applications, anthropologists are left to improvise as best they can. For counsel on these matters—for the costs of infringing the morality of anthropology—we must be grateful to Tom Csordas's searching article.

21. For an analysis of the medical principles of autonomy, nonmaleficence, beneficence, and justice, see Beauchamps and Childress (2008); for applications of these principles to anthropological practice, see the Code of Ethics of the American Anthropological Association, 2009, and pp. 69–71 of Haviland et al. (2010). These principles have been subject to critical questioning: they are charged by some to be underdetermined, by others to be culturally and politically biased.

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In the societies with which I am (more or less) intimately acquainted (Europe, U.S.A., India, and China), people make distinctions between good and bad, just as they make distinctions between beautiful and ugly, powerful and powerless, or, even more broadly, between day and night, young and old, et cetera. For the comparative study of society the importance of these distinctions is that, while they are universal, they are applied in very different ways. So, while the distinction between hot and cold is universal, it is applied in India, for example, to eating meat versus eating vegetables that have consequences for one's entire quality of being. Such are the moral consequences of certain food habits, but inversely there is also an understanding in India that one's birth in a particular social group determines who one is and what one eats. This explains why the warrior has to kill and why the Brahman refrains from killing. Killing is not reprehensible, as it belongs to the nature of the warrior. Certainly, not killing is superior to killing, but in order for some to be able not to kill, others have to. India offers us a case of moral relativism, related to a hierarchical social system. However, since the nineteenth century, reformers in India have wanted to reform this way of thinking, because, as they argue, it implies a system of social discrimination against untouchables who do impure work; it goes against one of the basic tenets of a modern society, the moral value of social equality. What we have in the anthropology of India is research on uneasy combinations of caste and class, of hierarchy and equality, of social impurity and hygiene. Indian society emphasizes right behavior in terms of family, sexuality, gender, and food; it is, at the same time, a society with extreme inequality, extreme infant mortality, and extreme poverty. It is highly moral and highly immoral at the same time, depending on one's viewpoint.

My point here is that one needs to connect political economy and moral economy. The idea (ascribed to Fassin) that one can distinguish a separate domain of culture that is called “morality” is unhelpful. The notion of moral conflict (ascribed to Robbins and Zigon), which contrasts moral stability with moral change and upheaval, seems to me equally unhelpful. In the societies that I know, moral ambivalence and ambiguity, as well as the constant appraisal of new situations, is always present. It is hard to discern a situation of moral stability that is suddenly disrupted. In fact, it seems to be in the nature of morality that it is unstable and constantly invites questioning and debate. In China (and even in the anthropology of China) there is some debate of the decline of morality with the rise of capitalism today. This is a moral discourse that should not be taken for granted but understood in relation to conflicting arguments about what it means to be a good person in China today. It should definitely not be understood as a sudden moral change in relation to a period

of moral stability in Maoist China. It would probably be fruitful to analyze such discourses of moral panic to shifting relations in the family and to Chinese understandings of power and money. This, obviously, requires ethnography of social inequality and of relative access to what is locally understood as “the good life.” No doubt, suffering is part of life, but, again, it cannot be understood in generalized, universal terms (as in Weber and Geertz). It has to be understood through the analysis of cultural debate in situated social life.

In short, I do not agree with Csordas that we have here the emergence of a new field in anthropology. Moreover, what we have to be wary of is to take recourse to “evil” as a metaphysical object. In my experience with victims of communal violence in India, of the cultural revolution in China, of the wars in Vietnam, it is in the concrete, conflicting accounts and understandings of evil actions, of deep suffering, of terrible injustice that life is understood. These accounts and understandings are culturally and socially embedded to an extent that makes them hard for ethnographers to understand. For example, for victims of communal violence the question may be not so much what is “evil,” but what to do when the neighbors are undoubtedly part of “the evil” and when after the violence one still needs to live close to them? Their solution may resemble but in fact is quite different from the popular Western proverb “see no evil, hear no evil, speak no evil.” The ethnographic problem in such cases is not that of evil but that of silence.

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Among the multiple dimensions of social and cultural imagination, morality occupies a blurred place across social domains, being Religion, on the one hand, and Law, on the other, the traditional loci of the moral in classical anthropology. Tom Csordas’s article helps us think beyond tradition, pointing out a little addressed topic in the emerging subfield of the anthropology of morality: the notion of *evil*, which, by the way, was and still is of central concern in shamanic and witchcraft studies, and also in certain currents of contemporary philosophy. This article interrogates us about the possibility of defining morality “as a cultural system,” in Clifford Geertz’s sense. In doing so, the author seems to discard finally the idea of morality as a “cultural system” for a less systematic, dispersed set of moral meanings that traverse social life. In this undertaking he does not leave the central Geertzian concern on symbols and meaning. Ultimately, human action is mediated by symbols that condense and produce meaning. Here, meaning seems to be the master concept related to the anthropological study of morality. Among the cultural meanings that shape moralities, Csordas finds appropriate introducing cross-cultural notions of evil to enrich any anthro-

political approach to morality. In the multifarious realms of morality, evil appears as a complex idiom or code through which moral notions are expressed. And among cultural practices, witchcraft and sorcery are of central concern to understand how many societies build their moral frameworks. Regarded both as a human and a cosmological (or nonhuman) phenomenon, evil in Csordas’s view as a cross-cultural analytical category, might enlighten studies about what I may call the “moral installation in the world.” The latter is related with the existential approach to morality proposed in this article. But I consider that, in conceptual terms, morality is always hierarchically included in ontology (what is the nature of the world) and epistemology (how the world is known). For morality is shaped by ontological and epistemological assumptions; further, it can be regarded as a sort of practiced ontology in the micropolitics of social life, organized by the cultural ways of knowledge acquisition (i.e., tradition, oral lore, literature, initiation, scientific training). In this sense, it is by no means a context-free concept; therefore, I concur with the author’s emphasis in moralities rather than its singular form. Nevertheless, anthropologists always are challenged by the risks of cultural relativism and moral relativism, which challenge in turn commonsensical structures of their own societies or communities of origin. Here—and no less important for our discipline’s health—the morality of anthropology appears in scene, but it should be treated on its own in future papers. Just in passing, the geopolitics of academia, and its connections with state policies nationally and internationally (i.e., Wright 2003) deserve critical approaches from different anthropological traditions.

While Csordas favors an analysis of evil in its “most immediate sense,” a caveat is needed here. Indeed, if he stresses “evil at the human and intersubjective level of analysis rather than to cosmological or radical evil,” how then does this match with his earlier statement about focusing on the “immediate existential sense” of evil, which cross-cultural ethnographies show more related to the cosmological, and/or the numinous dimensions defining the limits of morality? Moreover, for many societies, social ties link not only humans among themselves but also with many kinds of beings and what Westerners call “natural phenomena” and different sorts of materialities. So, the trope “a human phenomenon rather than cosmological or radical evil” tends to restrict the scope of the whole endeavor against a wider view of what “human” and “intersubjectivity” mean (see, e.g., Jackson 1998; Wright 2005). Even though I find positive the use of the notion of evil in this discussion, in the long run the “problem of evil” may result too Christianocentric and Western, in spite of Csordas’s efforts to neutralize its cultural load. As a suggestion, maybe the notion of “power” or “potency,” derived from Rudolf Otto’s work (1925), could provide a better term to refer both to the numinous/ominous cosmological forces involved in human moral life, and what Western Jungian psychology (Jung 2008) identifies as the “shadow” and its relations with personal Destiny. Here the dimensions of the

outside (cosmic) and the inside (psyche) might express their “power” and “potency” embedded in concrete individual and collective events.

Finally, I think that an anthropology of morality is, playing with neologisms in Csordas’s fascinating work, a true *anthropodicy*; that is, the never-ending quest for moral meaning, through cultural symbols, be they near and/or distant. There are many moral worlds, words, and practices throughout the planet—some very local, some quite global—and we anthropologists must honor our interlocutors’ quests for meaning, even though they may jeopardize our very existential structures.

Reply

I am grateful to this international group of scholars for accepting the invitation to engage my argument. My main points are that morality is not a cultural system but a modality of action present across all domains of human life, and that an anthropological approach to morality must recognize evil as an existential category. In other words, the article is neither a study of witchcraft for its own sake nor evil in its own right but a commentary on a particular moment in anthropological thinking about morality. Helene Basu recognizes the intent of my neologistic move toward homodicy and ethnodicy as alternatives to theodicy, which is to identify a starting point for anthropology distinct from those of theological anthropology or theology, in the shadow of which anthropology has approached morality obliquely if at all. She aptly identifies the importance of “concrete, situated human actions” and the “practical logic of evil.” To her question of whether this practical logic is discernible in violent encounters framed in terms other than witchcraft, the answer is an emphatic yes. Witchcraft is not the only evil, just as evil does not account for all of morality. Basu’s example of racial hatred in Germany shows morality as a modality of social action generating personal illness, collective suspicion and distrust, and an atmosphere of injustice. This supports my emphasis on the adjectival quality of moral action and moral interpretation rather than on a nominal morality, and on moral experience rather than on the structure of a moral code. Her interpretive polarity between police and immigrants might also be seen as a triangular one, including the violent right-wing xenophobes as moral actors, if there can be a morality of hatred. A practical contribution of evil as an analytic category in such an instance may be to help preserve cultural relativism while avoiding moral relativism.

Vincent Crapanzano adopts an aphoristic/interrogative style. He first asks whether it is possible to distinguish an anthropology of morality from the morality of anthropology. Insofar as we have not had a coherent anthropology of morality, I hope not—but I wonder if this implies a moral di-

mension of anthropology that goes beyond professional ethics. His second intervention suggests I fail to recognize that moral anthropology has often deflected ethnographic study of morality, though the newer studies to which I call attention do incorporate an ethnographic approach. He also wonders whether insistence by American anthropologists on egalitarian relationships in the field is an imposition of American values; one could extend this query to the well-intentioned but ironically nonegalitarian appropriation in the ethnographic aim of giving voice to the oppressed indigenous. Crapanzano’s third aphoristic query raises the relation among descriptive, normative, and universal morality while stopping short of asking how the rhetoric of the universal to which he refers might be related to the distinction between cultural and moral relativity. His fourth reflection is framed in terms of two distinctions (between political and moral, and between psychological and moral), but especially in the American society to which he refers it might be just as fruitful to put moral, political, and psychological idioms and attributions into a triangular relationship. Aphorism five is an injunction to consider the meta-moral, and I take this to mean both how morality is defined and where it fits into social discourse and ethnographic practice.

Question six raises the issue of whether the cultural systems that Geertz discusses—religion, ideology, aesthetics—are in fact any more systematically coherent than morality, extending this to the methodological relation between spiritual and moral and between spiritual and evil. Crapanzano is correct to identify the anthropological effacement of both spiritual and evil, though one might refer to both as insistent discursive shadows, rather than actual absences. In question seven, I agree that the reification and gothic characterization of evil may blind us to and add power to the rhetoric of evil. This is part of why anthropologists intuitively avoid evil, and precisely why I insist on the thematization rather than the reification of evil, and avoid the gothic characterization of evil to bring in the ethnology of witchcraft instead. Crapanzano’s attribution of evil to demons and devils in question nine plays into such a gothic characterization. In question eight, I am not certain that the identification of structural/symbolic oppositions qualifies me as a dualist in the usual sense, but certainly the specter of dualism that haunts the category of evil supports my argument for a need to rethink the category. This leads directly to the final question about the amoral and moral indifference. Thematizing evil rather than reifying it allows a distinction between saying “I don’t give a damn,” which is in fact a moral stance, and really not giving a damn, which is truly outside morality—this is related to the distinction between a criminal and a sociopath. Finally, Crapanzano’s reference to the bleaker side of human consociation prompts us to reiterate that evil is better examined not for its own sake but as integral to morality. Certainly amorality and moral indifference have moral and cultural consequences.

David Parkin identifies and endorses two points critical to my argument, namely, the methodological principle that “the

boundaries of the positive are predicated on the definitional challenges of the negative,” and the recognition that “evil is existentially present even if not amenable to set identification.” He refers to my observation that he purposefully excluded witchcraft from themes treated in *The Anthropology of Evil* and accepts my rationale for examining it here. It just may be that when his volume appeared nearly 30 years ago witchcraft was too obvious a place to look for evil, whereas to me it appeared a useful topic to revisit, given current intellectual considerations concerning morality. Interestingly, once Parkin accepts witchcraft as exemplary of human evil, as a move to demystify and de-theologize the category, he himself takes the next step of reintroducing evil conceived supernaturally and how it displaces culpability. The questions of whether evil attacks humans or lies among humans, and of whether evil is other than human or an extension of the human, call into question the boundaries of humanity. Independently of whether morality is divinely ordained or whether religion and morality are conceived as coterminous, the space between human and nonhuman is one of both moral and religious ambiguity. Witches may be something less than human, spirits may be in some respects like people and in others like animals, djinn may be like people except made of fire and air while we are made of earth and water, and angels or devils inhabit a preternatural world somewhere between the natural and supernatural.

Amélie Rorty, the one philosopher among the commentators, engages with the systematic elements of my argument: the problems of considering morality as a cultural system and of whether a systematic understanding of evil as a category is possible. She agrees that morality is not properly a system but a “polymorphous pluralism” in practice and observes that the multiple concerns of Anglo-American moral theory exhibit distinctive and even incommensurable logics and rationales. Rorty, like Parkin, accepts that attention to the dark side can illuminate what is at stake in morality but is surprised at my focus on evil as the “primary default contrast.” As with Crapanzano’s reading of my argument as dualist, I must rejoin that I take evil to be not so much a default contrast as an existential possibility that subtends morality and makes it necessary. However, the core of Rorty’s commentary makes it clear that the category of evil exhibits multiple concerns that are just as incommensurable and unsystematic as those of morality in general. In a tour de force paragraph that is both analytic and historical, she parses 11 components of evil broadly conceived (I only wonder if there are others, including violence and wickedness) and weaves them into a coherent narrative of incommensurability (I only wonder if this is lack of a system or complexity of a system). This is particularly valuable because it makes me realize the extent to which my argument is inflected toward one of those components, namely, malevolence. Finally, I reiterate that philosophers have not been as reticent as anthropologists to engage evil (see my footnote listing several recent philosophical works on the topic, not least among which is a book by Rorty herself). I resist

attributing this to philosophers’ ethnocentrism. As Rorty observes (and Crapanzano as well), it has something to do with the morality of anthropology as a social practice.

Peter van der Veer engages the issue of how to approach morality and whether there is a distinctively new anthropological approach. Noting that there are moral universals but that they are applied in distinctively different ways across cultures, he offers India as an instance of moral relativism related to a hierarchical social system. Although I am uncertain that the hierarchical values of obligation, status, innate constitution, and disposition are not themselves moral, I agree with his argument for connecting political economy and moral economy, for this is the surest way to highlight the omnipresence of moral ambiguity, ambivalence, argument, and appraisal, as well as the situatedness of moral action in social life. However, when van der Veer asserts that there is not a new field of study emerging around morality, it is unclear whether he means that the cluster of approaches I outline do not constitute a coherent set of interests or that they should not. Certainly the approach I refer to as “local moral worlds” somewhat predates the others, but in general these authors appear to *think* they are establishing a field rather than just addressing a topic. Personally, I am not a proponent of any of them but am pointing out something I think is necessary if there were to be a coherent approach. I also agree that we should not take recourse to evil as a metaphysical object, which is precisely why I elaborate it as an existential category instead. Recognizing this would allow van der Veer to remove the scare quotes from “evil” in his final sentences. When the neighbors next to whom one must live after the violence are part of the evil, the need to hold one’s tongue is not a problem of silence *instead* of evil. An alternative to the proverb cited by van der Veer might be the statement of Martin Luther King: “I was not afraid of the words of the violent, but of the silence of the honest.”

Pablo Wright observes that while I leave behind Geertz’s concept of a cultural system with respect to morality, I retain the Geertzian concern with symbols and meaning. I would not dispute Wright’s statement that meaning is the master concept on a methodological level prior to the substantive issue of evil but would stress that in addition to idiom, code, practice, and symbol, experience must figure into a comprehensive account. Wright’s evocative references to “moral installation in the world” (one might consider terms like investment, suffusion, and tonality, as well as installation) and morality as a “practiced ontology in the micropolitics of social life” deserve further elaboration. Wright endorses a pluralized notion of moralities, but I reiterate that even more important is an adjectival sense of moral rather than the nominal morality. Like Parkin, Wright poses the question of how to reintroduce the ethnographically salient notions of cosmological and radical evil once evil is first construed as a human and intersubjective phenomenon. The answer is to ask how these dimensions come into play in the experiential immediacy of social life, for example, how a cosmological battle between

angels and devils is experienced concretely on the human scale. Finally, he suggests that concepts of power from Otto and the shadow from Jung may be alternatives to the notion of evil, though I rejoin that they are just as much in need of critique with respect to Christian overtones. They may be valuable for the study of morality but are not suitable replacements for evil in the sense for which I have argued.

—Thomas Csordas

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